



FIELDWORK REPORT

SUBMITTED BY: Aparna Bastin

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ABSTRACT

This report provides a comprehensive overview of the implementation of five key government schemes—**MGNREGA**, **ICDS**, **Pension**, **Mid-Day Meal**, and **PDS**—in Mangrul village, along with insights from institutional visits to **APMC (Agricultural Produce Market Committee)**, **MSRTC (Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation)**, and **Tuljapur Municipality**.

Field observations in Mangrul village reveal a gap between the intended objectives of these schemes and their actual functioning. **MGNREGA** participation has declined due to low wage rates and allegations of job card misuse, where machinery completes work but payments are made to individuals, negating the employment creation goal. The **ICDS** scheme, targeting maternal and child welfare, showed inconsistencies in service delivery, with some Anganwadi centres performing better than others.

The **Pension System** revealed challenges faced by beneficiaries of various schemes, including irregular disbursements and the perception that banks deduct amounts from their pensions. Additionally, many recipients rely on middlemen for assistance in applying, leading to frustrations over high fees and complicated processes. The **Mid-Day Meal** scheme faced issues with food quality and irregular distribution, while the **Public Distribution System (PDS)** has improved post-digitalization, though middlemen still play a role, complicating access for some villagers.

Institutional visits further contextualized these challenges. At **APMC**, while the **eNAM** platform has expanded market access for farmers, logistical barriers and over-reliance on commission agents remain. The **MSRTC** continues to provide essential transport services in rural areas, though financial losses and maintenance challenges limit its effectiveness. The **Tuljapur Municipality** is focused on urban development through property tax collection, improving infrastructure, and addressing water supply challenges. However, issues such as traffic congestion, limited public spaces, and irregular water supply persist.

This combined overview of both village-level schemes and institutional operations reveals the complexities in delivering public services and highlights the need for improved governance and accountability to bridge the gap between policy and practice.

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Village Profile: Mangrul

Location

Mangrul is a village located in the Tuljapur tehsil of Osmanabad district, Maharashtra, India. It lies about 25 kilometers from the sub-district headquarters in Tuljapur and 33 kilometers from the district headquarters in Osmanabad. The village covers a total geographical area of **2,760 hectares**, surrounded by agricultural fields and small settlements. Despite its relative proximity to administrative centers, Mangrul faces challenges related to infrastructure and service delivery, typical of rural villages in the region.

Population

Mangrul has a population of approximately **10,000** people, distributed across **1,200 households**. The gender ratio is roughly **50:40**, with a slightly higher male population. The village is a close-knit community with people engaged in various occupations, primarily revolving around agriculture and related sectors.

Education

The village has a basic educational infrastructure to cater to the needs of its younger population:

- **Anganwadis:** There are **6 Anganwadis** that provide early childhood care and education for children aged 3 to 6 years, as well as support services for pregnant and lactating mothers.
- **Zila Parishad Schools:** Mangrul has **3 Zila Parishad-run schools** offering primary and pre-primary education. Additionally, there is a separate **Girls' School** and 3 other private schools.
- **College:** The village has **one college**, which provides higher education opportunities for the local youth, though many students migrate to larger towns for advanced studies.

Transportation

Mangrul is serviced by the **Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC)**, with buses running twice a day, except on Sundays. Prior to the COVID-19 pandemic, the bus schedule was more frequent, providing better connectivity. Now, limited public transport poses a challenge, particularly for the elderly who rely on these buses for commuting to nearby towns and cities for essential services.

Economy/Livelihood

- The economy of Mangrul is predominantly agrarian, with around **80% of the population engaged in agriculture**. The village's fertile land supports a variety of crops, contributing to the livelihoods of most households.

- About **10% of the population are migrant workers**, employed in nearby **sugar factories**. These workers often travel to the factories for seasonal work during the sugarcane harvesting season.
- The remaining **10%** of the population are involved in various other sectors such as **construction, running local shops**, or working in small-scale businesses like **medicine stores and grocery shops (kirana dukaans)**.

Health

Mangrul is served by a single **Primary Health Center (PHC)**, which provides basic healthcare services. However, for specialized medical care, villagers often need to travel to larger towns like Tuljapur or Osmanabad. While the PHC addresses common illnesses and provides vaccinations, more advanced medical facilities remain inaccessible.

Banking

The village has a branch of **Maharashtra Grameen Bank**, which caters to the banking needs of the local population. Many villagers rely on this bank for agricultural loans, savings, and other financial services, though the absence of more banking options can limit accessibility for some residents.

Water Supply

Water supply is a significant issue in Mangrul. The village receives water for only **2 hours a day**, which is insufficient to meet the growing needs of the population. To manage this shortfall, the **Gram Panchayat** frequently orders water tankers to supplement the irregular supply. This erratic water availability creates difficulties for both households and agricultural activities, especially during the summer months when water scarcity intensifies.

Public Distribution System (PDS)

Mangrul has **two public distribution centers** that operate for **2-3 days each month**. These centers provide subsidized food grains and other essentials to eligible families under the government's Public Distribution System. While digitalization has reduced corruption to some extent, there are still issues related to the quality of food grains and accessibility for some villagers.

Sarpanch

The village is governed by Sarpanch **Vijay Laxmi Dongre**, who oversees the local administration and development activities. The Gram Panchayat, under her leadership, plays a vital role in managing essential services like water supply, PDS, and village infrastructure.

Demography

The village is home to a diverse population, with **40%** of the residents belonging to the **Maratha** community. Other significant groups include **Muslims (10%)**, **Maatang (10%)**,

and a mixture of various other communities accounting for the remaining **40%**. This mix reflects the village's socio-cultural diversity, though caste-based hierarchies and social divisions persist to some degree.

ICDS (Integrated Child Development Services) in Mangrul Village

Mangrul village has a total of six Anganwadis, serving an estimated population of 4800 people. According to current population norms, one Anganwadi should serve a population

between 400 and 800. Two Anganwadis were visited as part of the fieldwork.



Anganwadi Staff and Facilities

The first Anganwadi we visited had a worker (AWW) who was 10th pass with 10 years of experience, and a helper (AWH) who was also 10th pass with 5-6

years of experience. In the second Anganwadi, the worker had a Master's degree (M.A.) and the helper had a diploma in education. Both Anganwadis were situated close to each other but lacked a compound wall. To address this, the workers planted plants to create a natural boundary to prevent children from wandering off.

Children and Activities

The children enrolled were aged between 3-6 years, with a current male student majority, though previously more female students were enrolled. Meals provided to the children include kheer in the morning and khichdi in the afternoon. Both Anganwadis have a vegetable garden, maintained by the workers, from which produce is used as supplementary vegetables for the children's meals. Occasionally, parents celebrate their child's birthday by providing eggs or special meals for all the children.

The Anganwadis also organize an annual trip to nearby locations for the children's enjoyment and celebrate festivals with various activities like dancing and singing. The first Anganwadi was better equipped, even having an LED TV for educational purposes, while the second was newly built and still awaiting toys and learning materials, which are expected next year.



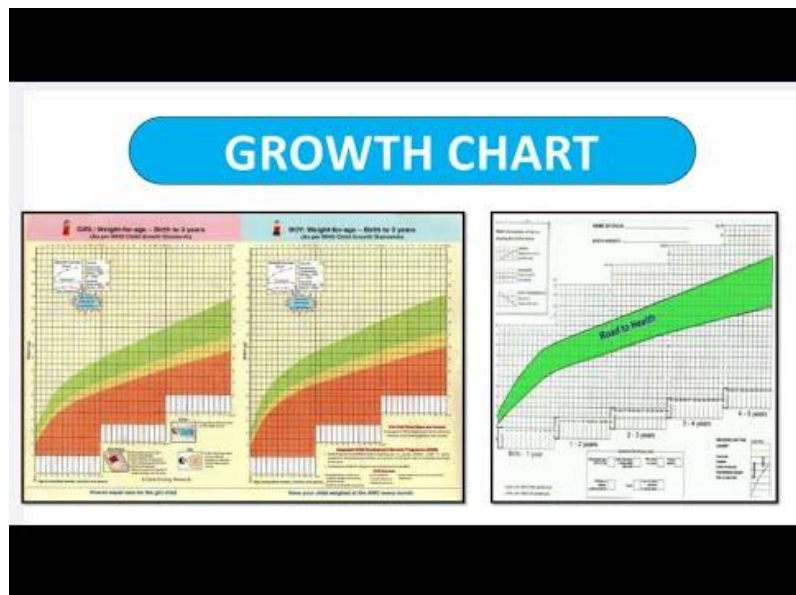
Health Monitoring and Nutritional Support

Monthly weight check-ups are conducted, and there is a standard food chart to guide the diet

of children who are underweight or overweight. Only one case of an underweight child was reported in the past 10 years. Take-home rations are distributed to adolescent girls every two months. Pregnant women are given nutritional counseling, although some women reported dissatisfaction with the quality of food and medications provided. Some pregnant women stated that they relied on private healthcare for medicines as they believed the Anganwadi-provided supplements were ineffective. Language barriers were also highlighted, as some pregnant women who speak Hindi struggled to understand the Marathi-language sessions without help from others.

Additionally, baby kits with clothes and toys are provided to first-time mothers. However, this provision does not extend to subsequent children, and the quantity of toys varies based on economic conditions. The

village Sarpanch mentioned that promises of sanitary napkins and sanitizers from the central government were yet to be fulfilled.



Operational Challenges

Some children are dropped off at the Anganwadi as early as 7 AM due to their parents' work schedules, although the Anganwadi opens at 9 AM, leaving the children waiting outside. During the summer, only meals are provided, and no classes are conducted. Workers are entitled to only 15 days of leave per year, and if one worker takes leave, the other must perform both roles, increasing the workload.

Labour Union and Demands

Both the AWW and AWH are part of labor unions advocating for better wages, gratuity, pensions, and paid leave. They currently earn between ₹10,000-15,000 for the AWW and ₹5,000-6,000 for the AWH, which they consider inadequate. They are not eligible for pensions and have been writing to higher authorities for these rights without any response so far.

One AWH shared her frustration about being unable to find better job opportunities despite holding a diploma in education, highlighting the growing competition and the unaffordable demands made by private institutions.

Mid-Day Meal Scheme in Mangrul Village School

During our field visit to the village school in Mangrul, we observed the functioning of the Mid-Day Meal (MDM) scheme. The school caters to students from grades 1 to 7. While the school is co-educational from grades 1 to 4, grades 5 to 7 are reserved for girls. Boys from grades 5 to 12 attend classes in a separate building, but girls can also join from 9th grade onwards.

Food Distribution and Nutrition

The stock for the mid-day meals arrives every two months. There are two cooks responsible for preparing meals, which primarily consist of masoor dal (lentils) and rice. On Fridays, additional supplements like eggs, laddus, iron tablets, and bananas are supposed to be distributed. However, on the day of our visit, which was a Friday, none of these supplementary items were provided. The food quantity served is 100 grams for children in grades 1 to 5, and 150 grams for students in grade 6 and above.

All records regarding stock arrival, student attendance, food served, and leftovers are meticulously maintained by the school teachers. Additionally, the children's weight is

regularly recorded as part of health monitoring.



Challenges and Observations

The teachers expressed concerns regarding sanitation and hygiene, particularly with

the state of the school's toilets. They mentioned that while there is a designated girls' toilet, it is not maintained properly, raising hygiene concerns. This lack of cleanliness extends to other areas, as the plates provided for our meal tasting were unwashed and stained with food from previous use. Additionally, the food served was undercooked, raising further questions about the quality of meal preparation.

Although the main goal of the MDM scheme is to improve school enrollment, many students bring their own tiffins from home due to the better quality of food available at home. This prompted the teachers to highlight the need for an improvement in the quality of meals served under the scheme. They also noted that students, particularly from more affluent backgrounds, tend to avoid eating the mid-day meal due to these quality issues.

Administrative Burden on Teachers

The teachers use an app called the MDM app to handle record-keeping tasks. However, they expressed concern about the amount of time they spend managing the administrative aspects of the mid-day meal scheme. This leaves them with less time for academic responsibilities. They suggested that the government appoint a separate department or personnel to manage the MDM records and logistics, allowing teachers to focus more on education.

Handling of Contaminated Food

Another issue raised was the handling of food infested with insects. For example, if insects are found in kabuli chana (chickpeas), the cooks simply dry the chickpeas in the sun, which they claim drives the insects away. This practice could raise potential health concerns, as the method does not eliminate any possible contamination or risk of foodborne illnesses.

Pension Schemes in Mangrul Village

In Mangrul village, three main pension schemes are in operation: the Shravan Bal Pension Scheme (Maharashtra), the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS), and the Rajiv Gandhi National Pension Scheme (Swavalamban Scheme). Additionally, there is the Kethi pension for farmers without land.

1. Shravan Bal Pension Scheme (Maharashtra)

This scheme provides financial support to senior citizens in Maharashtra who belong to families with an annual income below ₹21,000. Beneficiaries are entitled to a monthly pension.

2. Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)

Under this national scheme, citizens aged 60 and above who fall below the poverty line receive a pension. The pension amount varies based on the age of the recipient.

3. Rajiv Gandhi National Pension Scheme (Swavalamban Scheme)

This scheme aims to provide a pension for workers in the unorganized sector. It encourages individuals to voluntarily contribute to their retirement funds, with government contributions to match.

Kethi Pension for Farmers

This pension scheme is specifically for landless farmers, providing financial assistance to those without access to agricultural land.

Pension Distribution Issues

Recipients in Mangrul usually receive their pensions every three months, with the amount for three months paid together. However, this irregular distribution makes it challenging for pensioners to manage household expenses on a monthly basis. Many recipients expressed difficulty in budgeting when the pension payments are not consistent.

Additionally, several pensioners mentioned that they feel banks deduct a certain amount from their pensions before disbursing the funds. For example, one recipient reported receiving ₹1200 instead of the ₹1500 to which he was entitled. This discrepancy adds to the financial strain on pensioners.

Challenges in Applying for Pension

Many pension recipients said they often approach middlemen for help in applying for pensions, as they lack the knowledge or resources to navigate the application process themselves. However, middlemen charge high fees, which discourages some people from applying at all.

Old vs. New Pension Scheme (OPS vs. NPS)

During our discussions with some government school teachers who are pension recipients, a key issue that emerged was the comparison between the Old National Pension Scheme (OPS) and the New Pension Scheme (NPS).

Under the **Old Pension Scheme (OPS)**, pension amounts were calculated based on the last drawn salary, and retirees received a guaranteed monthly pension for life, adjusted for inflation. This provided them with a stable post-retirement income and financial security. The OPS was a defined-benefit plan funded by the government.

In contrast, the **New Pension Scheme (NPS)**, introduced for government employees who joined after 2004, is a market-linked, defined-contribution plan. Pensions under NPS are dependent on the returns from the contributions made during the employee's service, creating uncertainty in the post-retirement income.

One recipient of the OPS expressed concern for his colleague, who is under the NPS, and hoped that his colleague would also be eligible for OPS. He highlighted that the OPS provided much more security compared to the NPS, where retirees are exposed to market risks and may not have the same financial stability after retirement.

MGNREGA in Mangrul Village

During our visit to Mangrul, we found that the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) was not as actively utilized as it once was. One villager remarked that in his younger days, there were many more MGNREGA recipients. However, the current daily wage rate under MGNREGA is ₹297, which is considered low compared to other local work opportunities, such as agricultural labor, where people can earn around ₹500 per day for fewer hours of work.

Many villagers believed that the decline in MGNREGA activity could be attributed to the upcoming Vidhan Sabha elections. They speculated that funds were being diverted to other schemes, such as the **Ladli Behna Yojana** and **Ladla Bhai Yojana**. These schemes are designed to provide financial assistance to women and men, respectively, in order to improve their socio-economic conditions. However, this belief is not entirely accurate, as funds allocated for specific government schemes like MGNREGA cannot be legally diverted to other schemes. Each scheme has a separate budget approved by the government, and financial transfers are monitored to ensure they are used for their designated purposes.

Another explanation offered by the locals for the lack of MGNREGA work was that there were no significant projects left to complete in the village. However, this reasoning did not hold up, as essential works like road construction are still under the scope of MGNREGA, and many of Mangrul's roads were filled with potholes and in dire need of repairs.

Types of Work under MGNREGA: Individual vs. Community Projects

MGNREGA work is divided into two main categories: individual beneficiary-oriented work and community development projects. Individual works, such as land development or well-digging, directly benefit specific households, particularly those belonging to marginalized groups like small farmers or Below Poverty Line (BPL) families. On the other hand, community projects, such as road construction or water conservation, aim to create durable assets that benefit the entire village. Both types of work are crucial to addressing personal and collective needs, but the lack of active projects in Mangrul suggested an underutilization of the scheme, especially in community development areas.

Job Cards and the Role of Middlemen

Upon further investigation, it was revealed that job cards were still being created for

villagers. However, many of these job cardholders were essentially "dummy" participants. For example, when a project such as well-digging was initiated under MGNREGA, a set of people with job cards would be registered for the work, but the actual work would be carried out by machines. The payment for the project would be credited to the job cardholders' bank accounts as if they had completed the work, but in reality, the money would be funneled to the machinery owners through middlemen. This practice violates the core principle of MGNREGA, which is to create employment for rural people.

According to the village **Sarpanch**, new job cards are often created for people the authorities know or trust. These selected individuals make the process of transferring money from their accounts to contractors smoother, facilitating the misuse of funds intended for workers.

One of the reasons this fraudulent practice occurs is the increased reliance on machinery for tasks like well-digging, which is considered more efficient than manual labor. However, this approach defeats the entire purpose of MGNREGA—providing employment opportunities for villagers. On paper, employment is created, but in reality, machines perform the tasks, and villagers remain unemployed.

Gender Division in MGNREGA Projects

The types of work under MGNREGA are generally divided by gender. Men are predominantly employed for physically demanding tasks like well-digging, while women are assigned to horticulture projects. However, given that machines are now doing much of the well-digging work, this division of labor makes little practical sense. It further reinforces outdated gender roles, while failing to address the actual employment needs of both men and women.

Public Distribution System (PDS) in Mangrul Village

Mangrul has two PDS shops that open for 2-3 days each month. The village's PDS system serves various types of ration cardholders, each entitled to different benefits. For instance, families with **Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) cards**—the most vulnerable households—receive **35 kilograms of food grains per family per month**, at subsidized rates of **₹3 per kg for rice, ₹2 per kg for wheat, and ₹1 per kg for coarse grains**.

Priority Household (PHH) cardholders, on the other hand, are entitled to **5 kilograms of food grains per person per month** at the same subsidized rates. This ensures that even larger families receive an adequate amount of food grains based on the number of household members.

Certain groups, like **farmers**, who already grow their own grain through agricultural activities, are not given grain through the PDS. Instead, they receive **cash benefits** equivalent to the value of the grains they would otherwise receive. This helps avoid duplication in the distribution of food grains and aligns with their needs, as they can use the cash for other essential household expenses.

Villagers mentioned that the **digitalization** of PDS processes in recent years has significantly reduced corruption. In the past, people with political connections often became PDS distributors, leading to mismanagement and favoritism. However, the new system has made it easier for qualified individuals to become distributors, making the process more transparent.

When we asked about what happens to leftover grains, the **Sarpanch** claimed that the surplus is used for public programs and events in the village. However, villagers expressed skepticism, stating that the extra food grains were likely being sold at market prices or higher elsewhere. They noted that the quality of the food distributed varied—sometimes good, sometimes bad, and other times just mediocre. They suspected that this inconsistency was a deliberate tactic: if people complained about bad quality one month, better quality would be provided the next to pacify them. Mid-level quality grains were given with promises of improvement, keeping villagers placated without real progress.



Middlemen and Barriers to Access

A notable issue in the PDS system was the presence of middlemen. We spoke to one villager who had been living in Mangrul for 15-20 years but still did not have a ration card. He claimed that since he was not originally from Mangrul, he was denied the card despite living and working in the village. Middlemen often exploit such situations, charging exorbitant fees—up to ₹4000—to assist people in registering for ration cards. This discourages many eligible individuals from joining the PDS system, further entrenching their vulnerability.

Additionally, some cardholders take advantage of the system by collecting their allocated grain and then selling it elsewhere for a profit. This practice undermines the purpose of the PDS, which is to ensure that food grains reach the needy at subsidized rates.

INSTITUTIONAL VISIT

APMC: Tuljapur Agricultural Produce Market

The **Tuljapur Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC)** was established under the **Maharashtra Agricultural Produce Marketing (Development & Regulation) Act, 1963**, specifically under Section 39(J). Tuljapur APMC officially registered as an independent entity on **16th December 1984**, prior to which it functioned as a sub-market of the Osmanabad APMC.

The governance structure of Tuljapur APMC consists of an 18-member committee:

- **11 members** from rural society (society members who are the voters)
- **4 members** from Gram Panchayats
- **2 members** elected from licensed traders
- **1 member** from the registered labor community within the APMC

Financial Overview (FY 2024-25)

- **Income:** ₹14,262,055
- **Expenses:** ₹12,378,062
- **Surplus/Increase:** ₹1,883,993

TYPE OF LICENCES	No. of Holders
Hamal	97
WEIGHMAN	7
Commission Agent	105
Trader	225
Processor	0

APMC Trading Process

Farmers bring their agricultural produce (such as cereals) to the APMC, where the produce undergoes refinement processes. The **bidding process** is managed by commission agents, with licensed traders and farmers participating.

- **Commission Agents:**

- Earn a commission of **1.90%** of the total sale amount.
- Prior to 2016, this commission was borne by the farmers, but now the traders are responsible for paying it.
- The agents serve as intermediaries and often provide credit to farmers for inputs such as seeds and fertilizers.

- **Payment to Farmers:**

- Farmers are expected to be paid for their produce within **24 hours** of the sale. However, this often depends on the relationship and mutual understanding between farmers and commission agents.

Revenue Sources for APMC

APMC generates income through:

1. **Tax collection** from traders
2. **Licence fees** from traders
3. **Rent** for market facilities



e-NAM: National Agricultural Market

Introduced in **2016**, the **eNAM (National Agriculture Market)** is a **unified national trading platform** for agricultural commodities, linking APMCs across the country. This digital platform enables both traders and farmers to trade agricultural products seamlessly, providing a broader market reach and enhancing competition.

- **Benefits to Farmers:**

- eNAM provides access to a larger number of APMCs across India, increasing the chances of getting better prices for their produce.
- Farmers from Tuljapur, for instance, can now have their produce purchased by traders from other regions. Similarly, traders from Tuljapur can buy commodities, such as Kashmiri apples, from far-off locations.

Challenges Faced by APMC

1. **Monopoly and Monopsony:** APMCs often control both the selling and buying sides of the market, creating an imbalance in price determination. Traders can manipulate prices, forcing farmers to sell at lower rates than market value.
2. **Overdependence on Commission Agents:**
 - Farmers rely heavily on commission agents instead of directly interacting with traders. This often leads to fewer choices and higher dependency on middlemen for credits and inputs.
3. **High Barriers for Traders:**
 - Obtaining a trading license requires a **deposit**, which can be prohibitively high, limiting the number of traders who can participate. This reduces competition and keeps prices low for farmers.
4. **Challenges with eNAM:**
 - While eNAM offers an excellent platform for national trade, **transportation** remains a significant hurdle. The cost and logistics of moving goods from one part of India to another often limit farmers from fully utilizing the platform.

MUNICIPALITY

Tuljapur Development Overview

The Municipality of Tuljapur has identified the need for rapid development of the town to meet the demands of its growing population. As the town expands, the municipality is focusing on improving public goods and services, including transportation, residential areas, and public facilities. Several areas within the municipal limits are reserved for the expansion of these facilities to accommodate the increasing population.

One of the key goals of the municipality is to improve transportation within Tuljapur. Proposals have been made to upgrade parking facilities to reduce traffic congestion. Additionally, the municipality plans to develop open spaces, parks, and playgrounds, which are currently lacking in the town.

Property Tax System

The Municipality collects yearly property tax from residents and businesses, imposing different rates based on the type and condition of the property.

- **Tax Rates:** Residential properties pay a lower tax rate compared to commercial properties. Taxes include:
 1. Property Tax
 2. Tree Authority Tax
 3. Fire Extinguisher Tax
 4. Education Tax
 5. Employment Guarantee Tax
- **Tax Collection:** Property tax collection by the Municipal Corporation of Tuljapur exceeds ₹2 crores annually. After every four years, the tax rates increase, reflecting changes in the property's value. Residents receive their tax bills in September, and after construction, new buildings are exempt from taxes for one year. However, tax is imposed after that period.
- **Enforcement:** A strict system is in place to ensure compliance. The municipality maintains a separate register for private and commercial property taxes. If a property owner fails to pay the tax after receiving three warnings, the municipality can take strict action, including confiscating the property.

Education Initiatives

The Municipality oversees three schools, with two currently functional. These schools are part of the Nagar Parishad's effort to provide quality education in Tuljapur.

- **First School:** This school has 15 classrooms, 21 teaching staff, and provides education from 1st to 8th standard, catering to over 400 students.
- **Second School:** Smaller in comparison, this school educates students from 1st to 7th standard with only 91 students enrolled.

Both schools provide free textbooks and uniforms to students, ensuring access to education for all children in the town.

Water Supply System

Tuljapur's water supply system is strained, with households receiving between 1,000 to 1,500 litres of water only twice a week for 45 to 60 minutes per supply period.

- **Water Tariffs:** Residential households are charged ₹2,400 annually, while commercial establishments pay ₹7,200. Water is sourced from Naldurg and treated at a water treatment plant before being distributed to the town.

Housing Development and Welfare Schemes

The Municipality participates in the **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)**, aiming to provide affordable housing for the economically weaker sections (EWS) of society.

1. **Beneficiary-Led House Construction or Enhancement (BLC):**
 - A Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) that provides central assistance up to ₹1.5 lakh per house to EWS families for constructing new houses or enhancing existing ones.
2. **Credit Linked Subsidy Scheme (CLSS):**
 - A Central Sector Scheme offering interest subsidies on home loans for EWS and lower-income group (LIG) families for house acquisition, construction, or enhancement.
3. **Affordable Housing Partnership:**

- This scheme offers financial assistance of ₹1.5 lakh per EWS house built through various partnership models involving the public and private sectors.

4. **Private-Public Partnership (PPP):**

- Builders handle construction under this model, providing affordable housing options for eligible families.
- **Eligibility Criteria:** Families with an annual income of up to ₹2.5 lakh are eligible for these schemes.

MSRTC

MSRTC (Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation): A Historical Perspective

The Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC) plays a significant role in



ensuring reliable public transportation across Maharashtra.

- **Pre-1948 Era:** Before MSRTC was established in 1948, private operators dominated the transport sector. This led to inconsistent services, unregulated fares, and a general lack of uniformity.
- **Post-1948 Development:** Recognizing the need for a standardized public transportation system, the government passed legislation to bring uniformity and regulate the sector, resulting in the establishment of MSRTC. The corporation now oversees transportation in the state, aiming to offer affordable and accessible services.

Organizational Setup and Structure

- **Head Office:** MSRTC's head office is located in Mumbai, from where the entire operation is managed.
- **Division Offices:** There are 31 division offices across Maharashtra, ensuring wide-reaching services.
- **Depots:** The corporation operates 255 depots, each facilitating local transport needs.
- **Staffing:** MSRTC employs around 72,000 people, including 15,000 mechanical staff who ensure the buses remain functional and safe.

Services Offered by MSRTC

MSRTC provides a variety of bus services that cater to different segments of the population:

- **Types of Buses:** They offer multiple bus types, including AC buses (Shivsai), non-AC sleeper buses (Shenyayi), seater-sleeper hybrids, and city buses.
- **Fleet in Tuljapur:** The Tuljapur depot has 85 buses as of 2023. Despite population growth, fleet expansion has lagged behind.
- **Online Booking:** Passengers can book tickets through the MSRTC website and mobile app, making it easier to plan journeys.
- **Festival Buses:** During festivals, MSRTC introduces additional services to manage the surge in passenger demand.

The Role of the Mechanical Department

- **On-Road Repairs:** The mechanical department handles emergency repairs, including flat tire fixes and on-road breakdowns.
- **Pre-Travel Inspections:** Safety checks are done before buses leave the depots to ensure they are roadworthy.
- **Maintenance Challenges:** One key challenge is maintaining older buses, especially when spare parts and resources are limited.

MSRTC's Social Welfare Schemes

MSRTC has implemented several welfare programs to ensure affordability:

- **Students:** Rural students receive a 66% fare concession, while female students benefit from free transportation.
- **Women:** Women are offered a 50% discount on regular fares.
- **Senior Citizens:** Passengers aged 75 and above travel free, while those aged 65 to 75 enjoy a 50% fare concession.
- **Persons with Disabilities (PwDs):** PwDs with a disability level of 40% or more receive a 75% discount. Caretakers of PwDs with 65% or more disability receive a 50% discount.

Challenges Faced by MSRTC

While MSRTC serves a vast population, it grapples with numerous challenges:

- **Financial Losses:** In rural areas, lower passenger numbers result in operational losses, which are usually reimbursed by the government.
- **Taxation:** The corporation has received some relief as the tax rate on its services has been reduced from 17% to 7.5%.
- **Ticket Prices:** Even with rising costs, MSRTC has maintained steady ticket prices over the past five years, adding strain on its financial resources.
- **Resource Constraints:** The mechanical department struggles with maintaining older buses due to a shortage of materials and spare parts.

CONCLUSION

The comprehensive examination of the various schemes implemented in Mangrul village, alongside the institutional visits to the APMC, MSRTC, and the municipality, underscores the critical intersection of public policy and rural development. While the initiatives aim to enhance the livelihoods and welfare of the community, several challenges persist, including inefficiencies, irregularities in service delivery, and the influence of middlemen. The insights gained from this study highlight the importance of ongoing dialogue among stakeholders to address these issues, improve service quality, and ensure that the benefits reach the intended beneficiaries effectively. Moving forward, it is imperative to focus on enhancing transparency and accessibility within these systems to foster sustainable development and empower the villagers.